Between Possessions and Purpose: Understanding My Material and Spiritual Self

At this point in my life as a college freshman, I understand the material self as the part of me that is connected to the things that I own, achieve, and present to others. This includes my belongings, my academic performance, and even how I appear in social situations. On the other hand, my spiritual self is more internal, it is shaped by my values, beliefs, sense of purpose, and the principles that guide my decisions.

I believe that my possessions, achievements, and external goals play a role in shaping my identity. Like doing well in school gives me a sense of accomplishment and builds my confidence. I sometimes associate my worth with my academic performance or how productive I am. There are also moments when I feel pressured to meet expectations, whether from family, peers, or even myself. These external influences can motivate me, but they can also make me feel like I am constantly trying to prove something. This made me realize that while material success is important, it should not fully define who I am.

At the same time, my beliefs and values strongly influence my decisions and relationships. I value honesty, respect, and personal growth, and I try to apply these in how I interact with others. For instance, I choose to be honest even when it is uncomfortable because I believe that trust is important in any relationship. My sense of purpose is still developing, but I know that I want to live a life that is meaningful and not just focused on achievements.

I once prioritize and attend a social activity over a responsibility, simply because I did not want to miss out or be left behind. At that time, the desire for enjoyment and belonging wins. But I realized that choosing short-term satisfaction is not going to make my life easier but it negatively affects my responsibilities and self-discipline. In the end, I chose to focus on myself and what I have to do. Although it was difficult, I felt a deeper sense of fulfillment because my decision aligned with my values. This experience taught me that true satisfaction often comes from making choices that reflect who I want to become, not just what I want in the moment.

A concept from our course that helped me understand this balance is Socrates' idea that "the unexamined life is not worth living." This idea made me reflect on how I make decisions, especially when I am torn between material desires and my deeper values. Instead of simply following what is easy or immediately rewarding, I am learning to question my intentions and think about the long-term meaning of my choices.

To create balance between pursuing material success and nurturing my spiritual well-being, I am learning to set priorities and reflect on my intentions. I remind myself that achievements are important, but they should serve a greater purpose rather than become the purpose itself. I also try to make time for self-reflection, whether by thinking about my actions or evaluating my decisions. By doing this, I can stay grounded and ensure that I am not losing myself in the pursuit of external validation.

Overall, understanding both my material and spiritual self is helping me grow into a more balanced person. While the material-self drives me to achieve and improve, the spiritual-self reminds me of what truly matters. As I continue my journey in college, I aim to maintain this balance by aligning my actions with my values, allowing me to live not just successfully, but meaningfully.